



NITI Aayog

DRAFT



Sector at a glance

Inbound Tourism

Tourism in India

2023-Inbound Tourism-SAG-02

DRAFT

Sector at a glance

Inbound tourism

Tourism

The **‘Sector-at-a-Glance’** provides an easy-to-read overview for anyone looking to develop a basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices where available from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, and government initiatives being undertaken in the sector. Finally, a ‘Way Forward’ section sets out the major developments that will shape the future of the sector.

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Overview



Inbound tourism serves as a vital pillar of economic development, contributing to revenue generation, job creation and foreign-exchange earnings for a host countries. It bolsters a nation's hospitality and service industries, driving infrastructure development and providing opportunities for local entrepreneurs.

In 2019, India attracted **10.9¹** million **Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs)**, recording a Compound Annual Growth Rate (CAGR) of 6.1% between Calendar Year (CY)14 and CY19.

Foreign Exchange Earnings (FEE) amounted to Rs. **2,16,467¹** crore, implying a CAGR of 10.3% between CY14 and CY19.

Inbound tourism serves as a catalyst for cross-cultural interactions, contributing to the cultivation of greater understanding and tolerance among diverse communities. The showcasing of a country's historical sites, natural landscapes, and cultural heritage not only enriches the experiences of international visitors, but also plays a pivotal role in enhancing the nation's image globally. This positive perception, in turn, attracts international investment, as the appeal of a destination extends beyond tourism to encompass broader economic opportunities. The cumulative effect is the potential for sustainable growth, an improved quality of life for local communities, and increased cultural exchange on a global scale. The reciprocal nature of inbound tourism positions it as a dynamic force that not only benefits the hosting nation, but also fosters meaningful connections and collaborations on the international stage.

India's global share of International Tourist Arrivals (ITA) was 1.22% in CY19. The top three countries for inbound tourism were Bangladesh, the United States (US), and the United Kingdom (UK). Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Uttar Pradesh were the top three states in terms of FTA visits in CY19.

Figure 1: Snapshot of inbound tourism



International tourist arrivals
(ITA) (CY19)

17.9 million



Share of India
world ITA (CY19)

1.22 %



Foreign exchange
earnings (CY19)

2,16,467 crores



International tourist visits
to states/UTs (CY19)

31.4 crores

Note: Due to the outsized impact of the Covid-19 pandemic on the tourism sector across calendar years 2020 to 2022, data for 2019 has been taken into account for a more representative analysis.

Source: Ministry of tourism, Government of India.

Sectoral trends

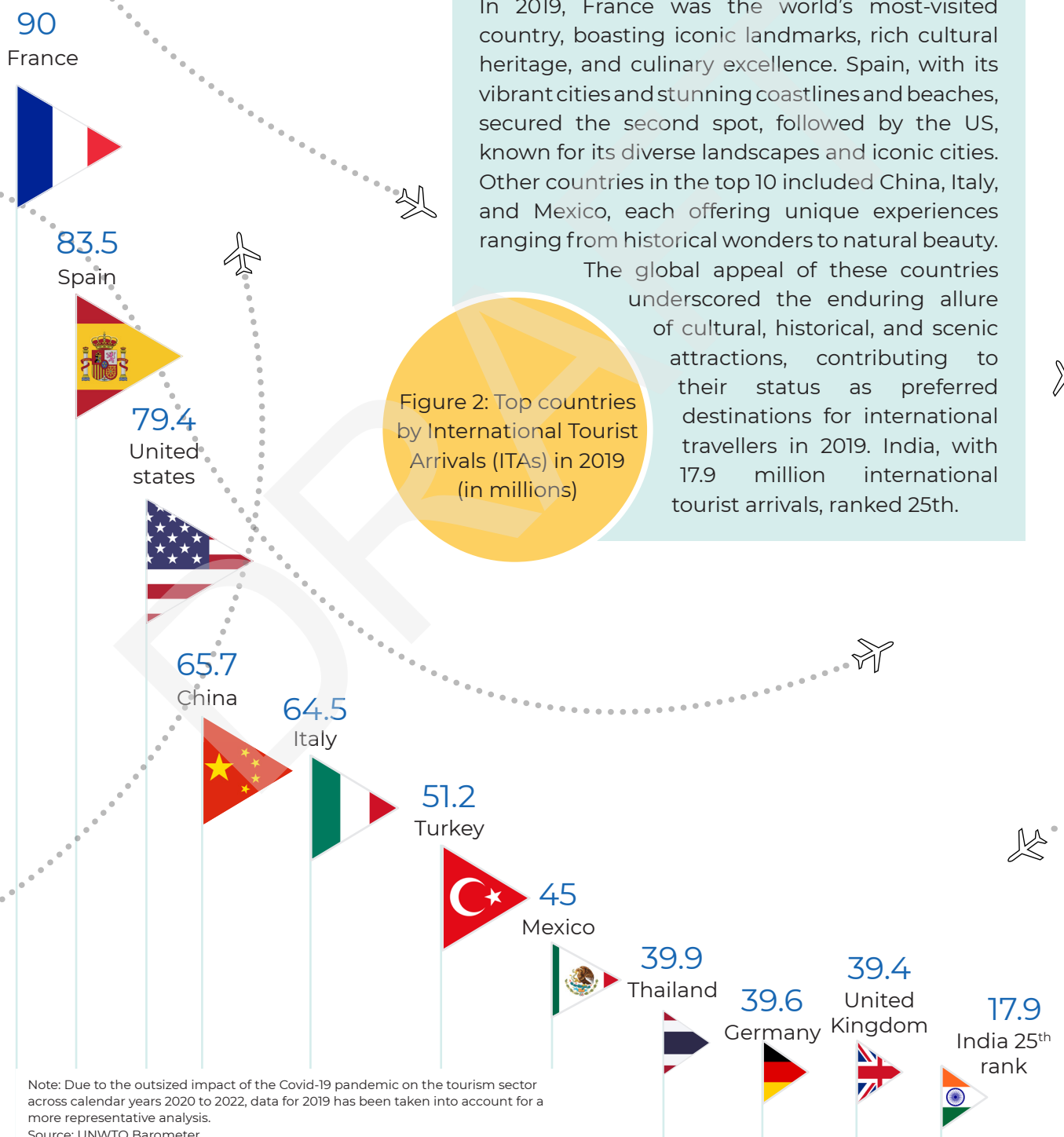
Global Scenario

Global Inbound Tourism

In 2019, France was the world's most-visited country, boasting iconic landmarks, rich cultural heritage, and culinary excellence. Spain, with its vibrant cities and stunning coastlines and beaches, secured the second spot, followed by the US, known for its diverse landscapes and iconic cities. Other countries in the top 10 included China, Italy, and Mexico, each offering unique experiences ranging from historical wonders to natural beauty.

The global appeal of these countries underscored the enduring allure of cultural, historical, and scenic attractions, contributing to their status as preferred destinations for international travellers in 2019. India, with 17.9 million international tourist arrivals, ranked 25th.

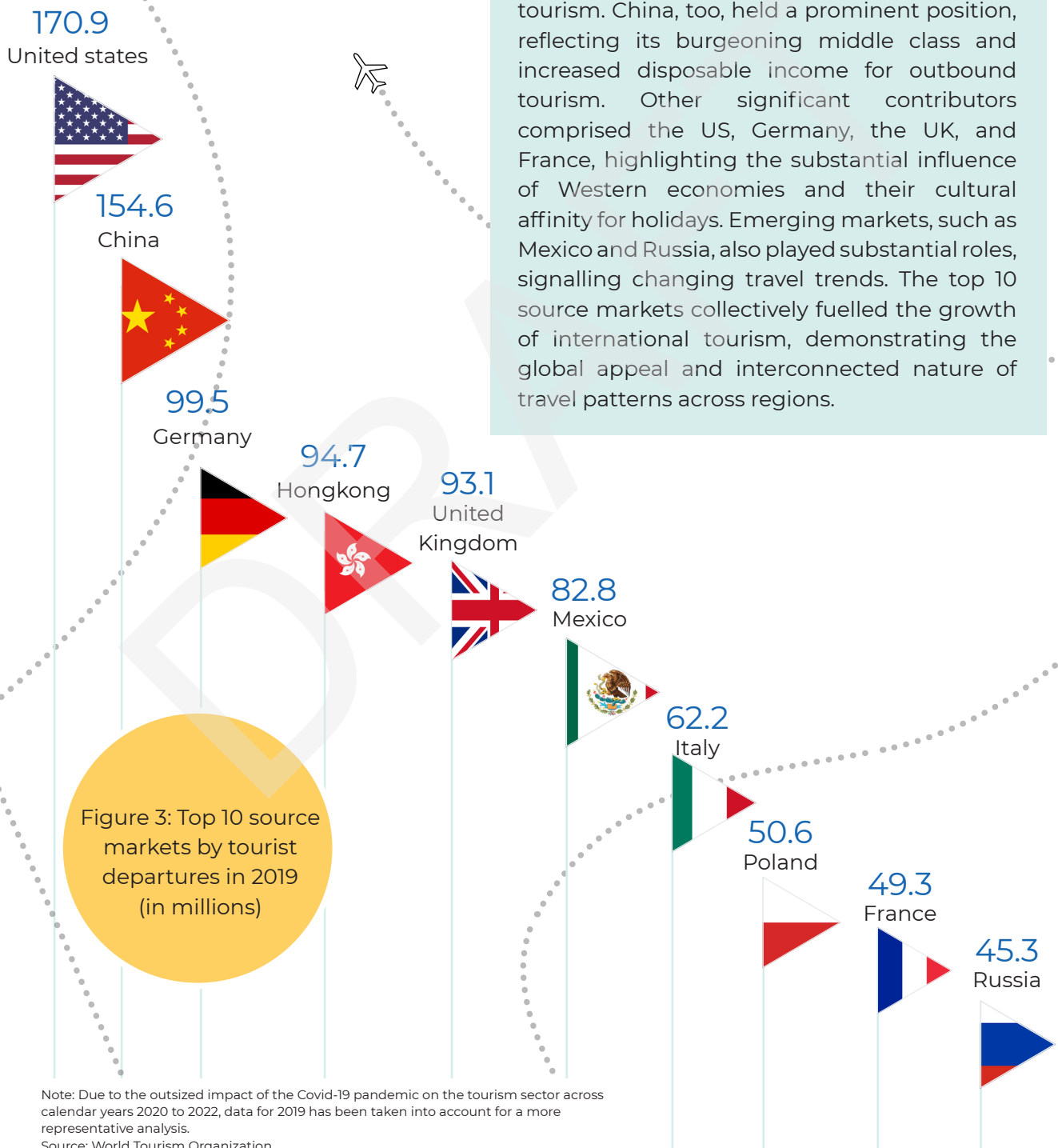
Figure 2: Top countries by International Tourist Arrivals (ITAs) in 2019 (in millions)



Note: Due to the outsized impact of the Covid-19 pandemic on the tourism sector across calendar years 2020 to 2022, data for 2019 has been taken into account for a more representative analysis.
Source: UNWTO Barometer

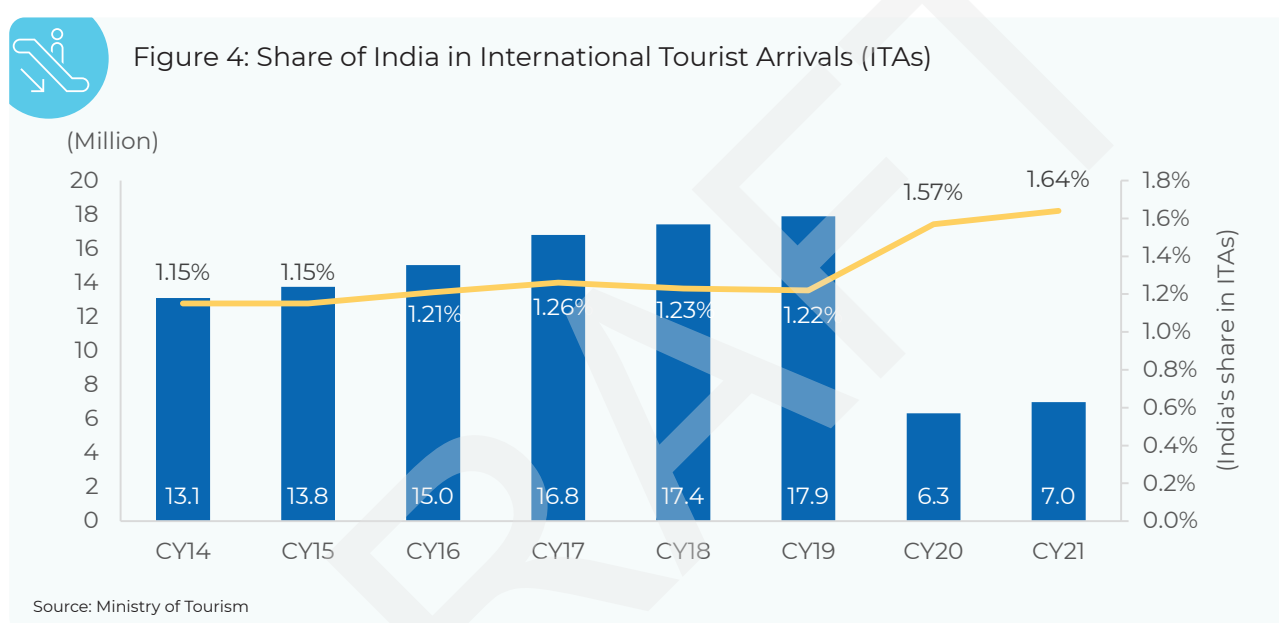
Global source markets for Inbound Tourism

In 2019, the top 10 source markets for international tourist departures represented a diverse range of countries, contributing significantly to global travel. The US emerged as the leading source market because of its high GDP per capita, supporting outbound tourism. China, too, held a prominent position, reflecting its burgeoning middle class and increased disposable income for outbound tourism. Other significant contributors comprised the US, Germany, the UK, and France, highlighting the substantial influence of Western economies and their cultural affinity for holidays. Emerging markets, such as Mexico and Russia, also played substantial roles, signalling changing travel trends. The top 10 source markets collectively fuelled the growth of international tourism, demonstrating the global appeal and interconnected nature of travel patterns across regions.



Inbound tourism in India

Between 2014 and 2019, International Tourist Arrivals (ITAs) in India experienced a steady annual growth rate of 6.4%, more than double the world average (3%), reaching about 18 million visitors. This growth was facilitated by efforts that enhanced tourist infrastructure, upgraded monuments, increased discoverability through digitalisation, and improved air connectivity. However, the Covid-19 pandemic significantly impacted tourism, resulting in a substantial decline of 64% in arrivals to 6 million in 2020. As scheduled international travel was suspended and leisure travel took a back seat, there was a modest recovery in 2021, with an 11% increase in arrivals to 7 million, but the numbers remained relatively low compared with the pre-pandemic levels.



India's share in the world ITAs has improved from 0.64% in 2013 to 1.22% in 2019. This positive trend in the country can be attributed to factors such as improved airline connectivity, eased visa requirements, and enhanced tourism promotion efforts. However, there is still significant scope for improvement for our country, which has the 7th largest land mass in the world and is home to one of the ancient wonders of the world and 42 UNESCO World Heritage Sites to name a few.

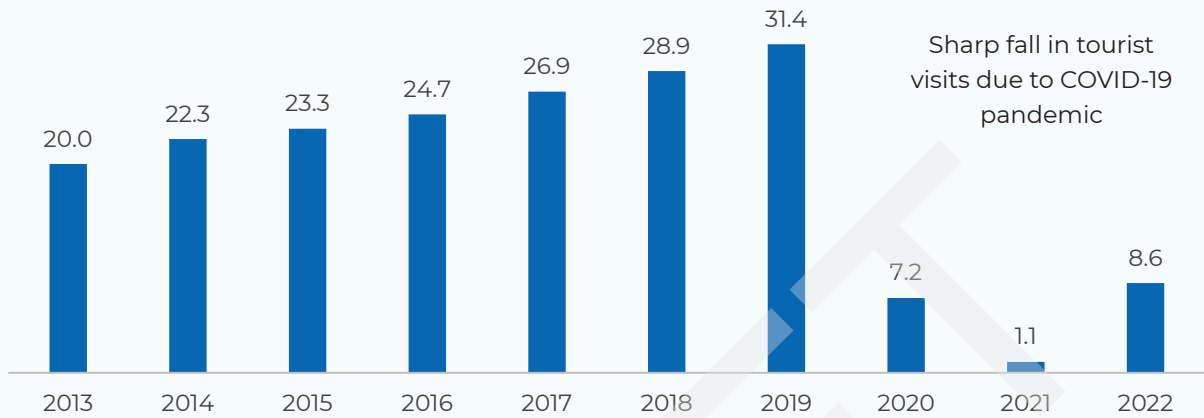
State-wise Tourist arrivals

In 2019, international tourist visits to states and UTs in India reached 31.4 million, logging a CAGR of 7% from 2013 to 2019. This influx significantly contributes to state economies, generating revenue for accommodations, transportation, dining, and local attractions. The economic impact extends to supporting local businesses, creating jobs, and enhancing infrastructure. Moreover, international tourism promotes a positive global image, attracting more visitors for repeat visits. It also plays a crucial role in preserving and showcasing the unique cultural identity of each state and union territory through the promotion of local arts, crafts, and traditions.



Figure 5: International tourist visits to states/UTs

Million

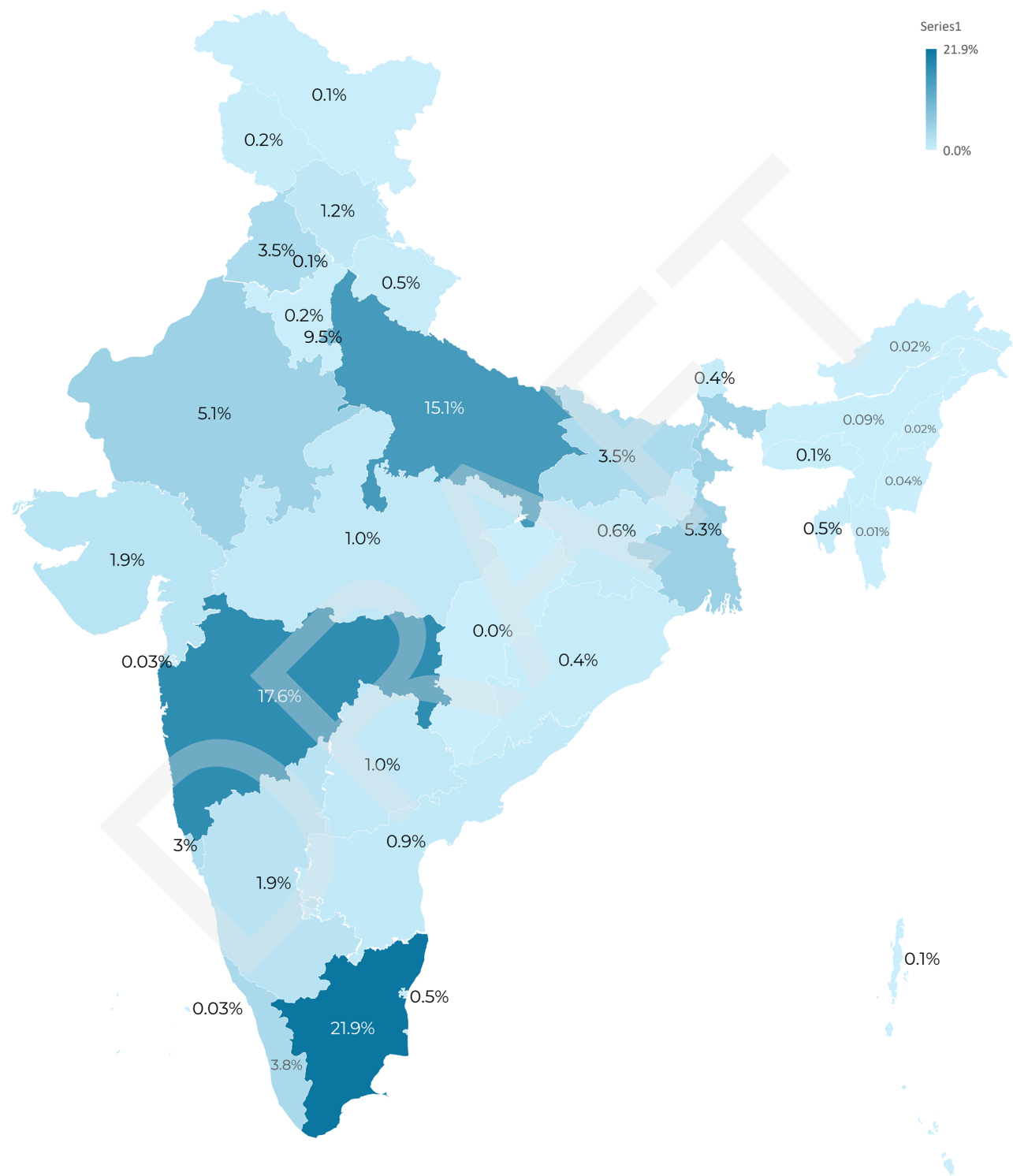


Source: Ministry of Tourism

Tamil Nadu stands out as the state that attracted the highest number of foreign tourists in India in 2019. This can be attributed to the diverse range of tourist activities it offers, including medical tourism, wellness retreats, spiritual tourism due to its numerous religious sites, as well as beach tourism. Maharashtra comes in second, followed by Uttar Pradesh, which also witnessed significant FTAs driven by visitors flocking to the iconic Taj Mahal. Combined, these top three states accounted for 55% of the total FTAs to states and union territories (UTs) in 2019.



Figure 6: State-wise foreign tourist visits

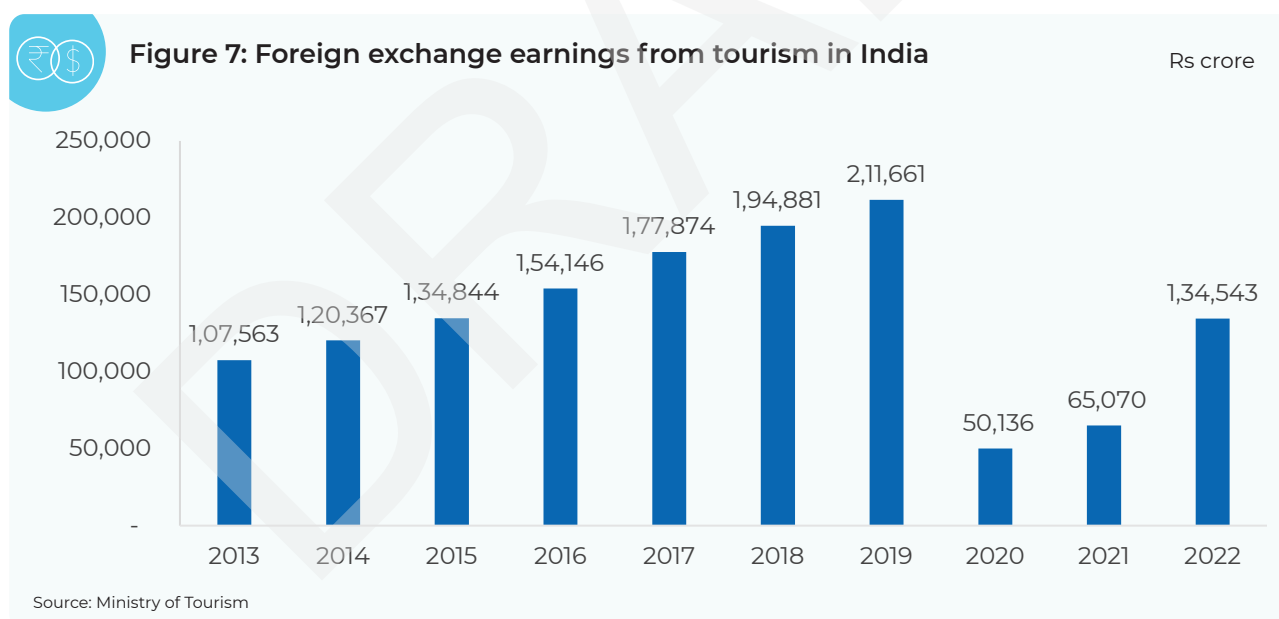


Source: Ministry of Tourism
Note: Due to the outsized impact of the Covid-19 pandemic on the tourism sector across calendar years 2020 to 2022, data for 2019 has been taken into account for a more representative analysis.

Foreign-exchange earnings

Foreign exchange earnings from inbound tourism play a vital role in the economic development of a country. When international tourists visit a destination, they spend money on various goods and services, including accommodation, transportation, dining, and souvenirs. The revenue generated from these expenditures contributes directly to the country's foreign exchange reserves. In many nations, tourism is a significant source of foreign currency inflow, helping to stabilize trade balances and supporting overall economic growth. Countries with popular tourist destinations strategically leverage their attractions to attract international visitors, recognising the substantial economic impact that tourism can have through the infusion of foreign currency into the local economy. Consequently, inbound tourism not only fosters cultural exchange, but also serves as a crucial economic driver, enhancing a nation's financial stability and contributing to its global economic standing.

India's foreign exchange earnings from tourism in 2019 amounted to Rs 2,16,467 crore, implying a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 10.5% from 2013 to 2019, surpassing the growth rate of FTAs during the period and indicating a higher spending per tourist. Improved tourist spending per passenger is a net positive for the nation, as it contributes to India's GDP and boosts foreign-exchange earnings. These earnings, in turn, aid in capital inflow and balancing the trade deficit, making tourism a significant contributor to India's economy.

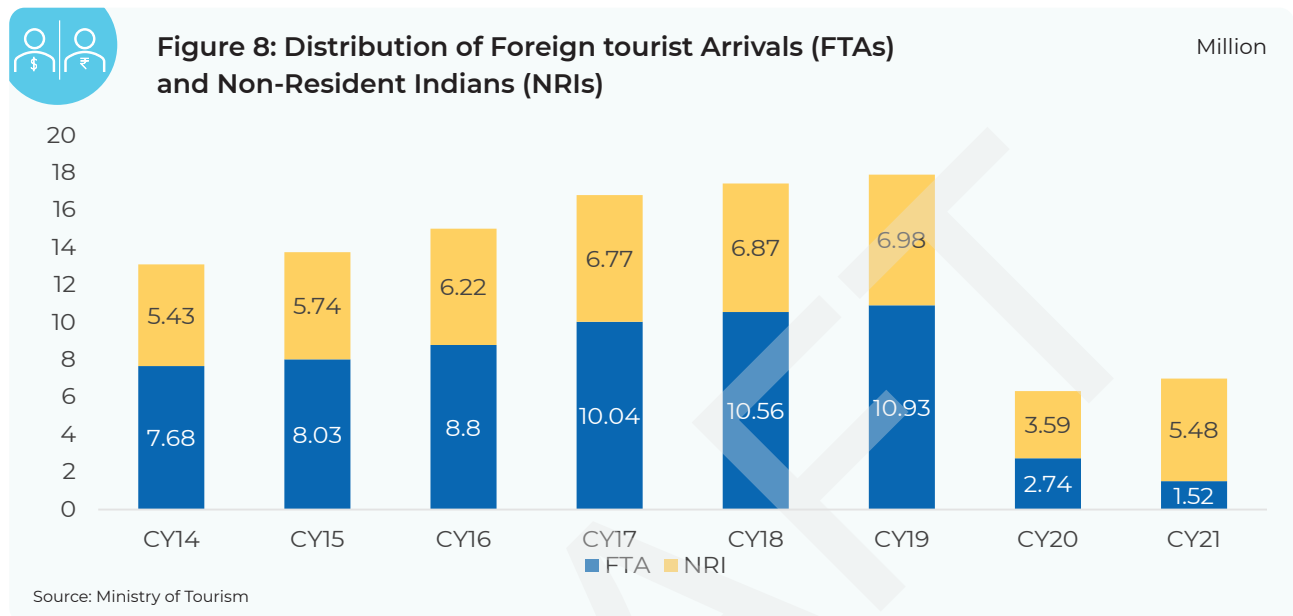


Distribution of International Tourist Arrivals (ITAs)

ITAs in India can be categorised into two segments: FTAs, i.e., tourists visiting India for tourism (leisure, business, Meetings, Incentives, Conferences & Exhibitions (MICE), and non-resident Indians (NRIs), mainly individuals visiting friends and family.

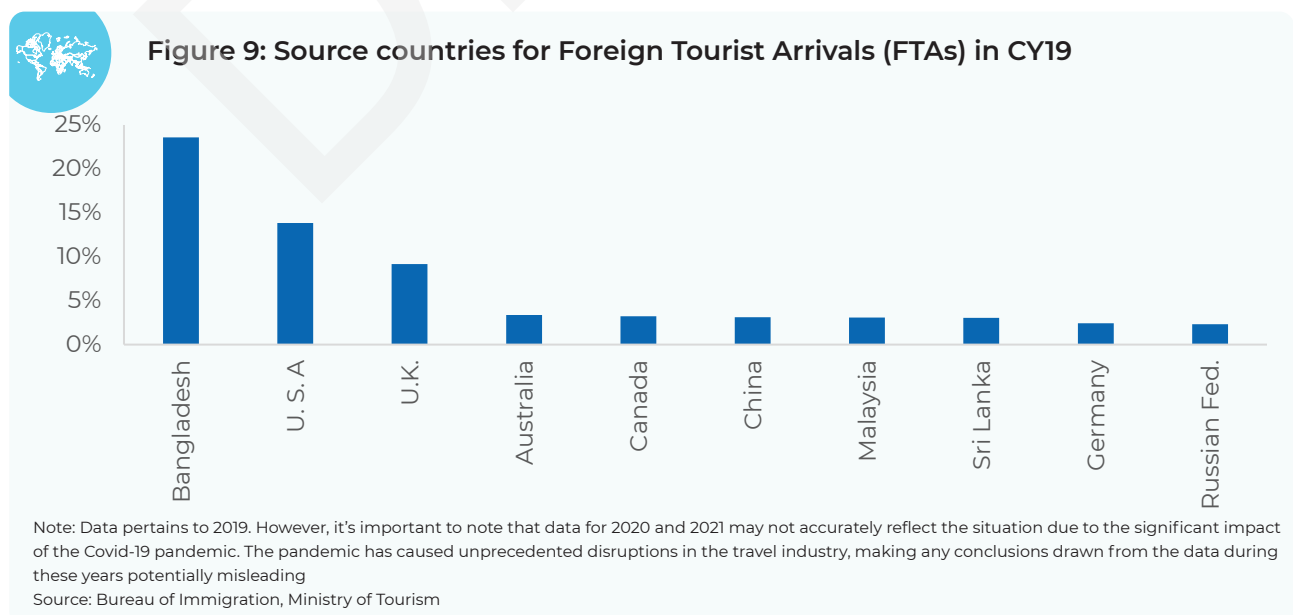
From 2014 to 2019, the number of FTAs grew 7.3%, resulting in an increase in the share from 58% to 61% of total arrivals in 2019. This growth can be attributed to the development of tourist infrastructure, monument upgrades, enhanced discoverability through digitalisation, and improved air connectivity. However, during the pandemic, the share of FTAs declined significantly to 43% in

2020 and further to 22% in 2021, as tourism activities were limited, and leisure travel was heavily impacted. In contrast, there was a notable increase in NRI arrivals during this period, driven by visiting friends and family and migratory traffic.



Source countries for Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs) in India

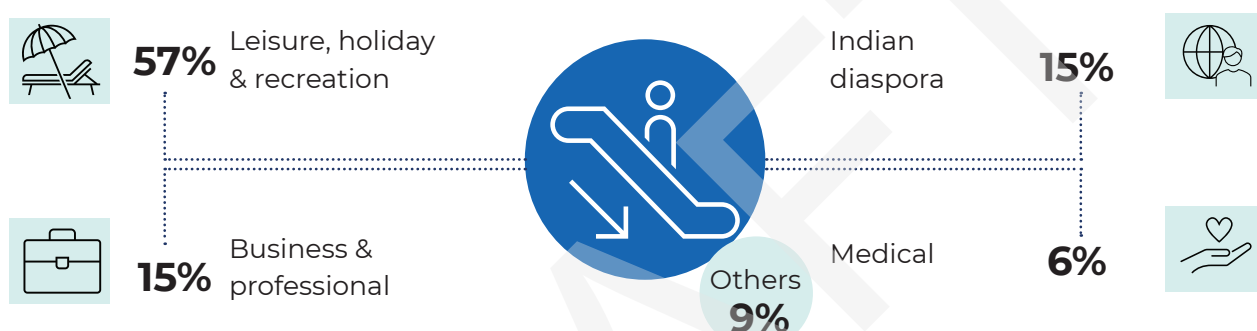
Bangladesh holds a significant share in tourist arrivals to India, accounting for nearly one in four visitors, primarily due to the common land border between the two countries, as well as strong people ties and business interests. Following Bangladesh, the US and the UK are the next major sources of tourists to India, representing 14% and 9% of total arrivals, respectively. Together, these top three countries contribute to almost half of the overall tourist inflow into India.



Purpose of visit of Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs) in India

In 2019, the largest portion of international visitors coming to India was for leisure travel, 57%. This category of travel encompasses heritage tourism, ecotourism, spiritual tourism and niche tourism, among various others. Following leisure travel, business tourism, which includes MICE, accounted for 15% of FTAs. This is due to India's thriving business community and its position as the fifth-largest economy globally. Medical tourism holds a 6% share, as India is renowned for its exceptional and cost-effective healthcare services, along with its promotion of alternative systems of medicine such as ayurveda, yoga, unani, siddha and homeopathy.

Figure 10: Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs) by purpose in CY19

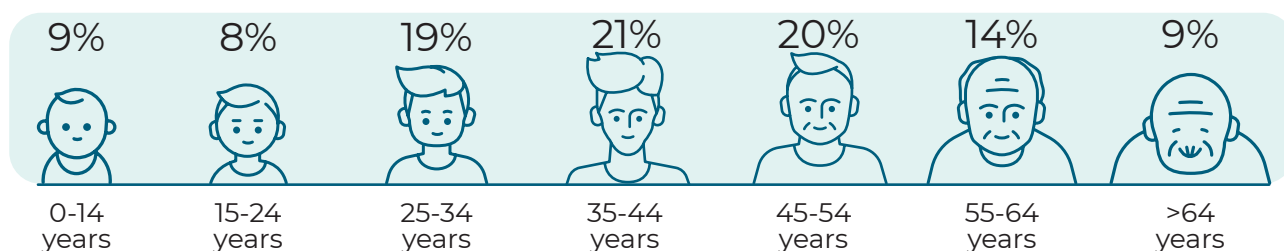


Note: Data pertains to 2019. However, it's important to note that data for 2020 and 2021 may not accurately reflect the situation due to the significant impact of the Covid-19 pandemic. The pandemic has caused unprecedented disruptions in the travel industry, making any conclusions drawn from the data during these years potentially misleading.
Source: Ministry of Tourism

Age group demographics of Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs)

The 35-44 age group constitutes 21% of travellers to India, closely followed by the 45-54 age group at 20%, and the 24-34 age group at 19%. This distribution underscores the significance of catering to tourists across all age groups, ultimately driving tourism numbers. While western countries typically have aging populations, Asian countries generally exhibit younger demographics. India, with its diverse range of experiences, is uniquely positioned to allure tourists from various age groups. By offering a diverse array of experiences and tailoring services to cater to the preferences and interests of different age demographics, India can effectively attract and accommodate visitors from around the world.

Figure 11: Age categories of Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs) in CY19

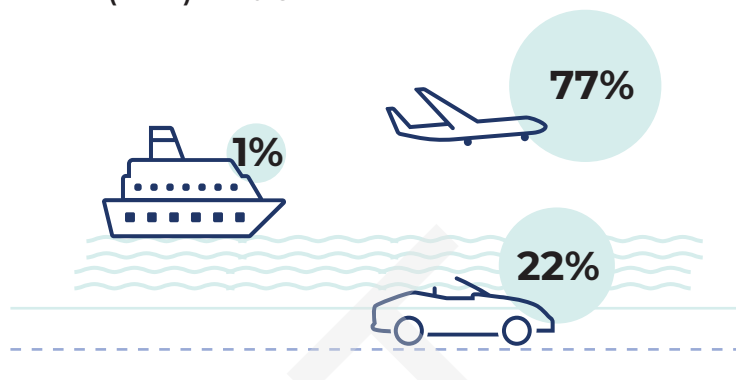


Note: Data presented here pertains to 2019. It is important to note that data for 2020 and 2021 may not accurately reflect the situation due to the significant impact of the Covid-19 pandemic, which caused unprecedented disruptions in the travel industry, rendering any conclusions drawn from the data during these years potentially misleading.
Source: Ministry of Tourism

Connectivity

Air travel plays a crucial role in India's tourism sector, with over three quarters of inbound tourists arriving by air. In comparison, land borders account for 22% of tourist arrivals, and sea-entry points represent the remaining portion. The significance of a robust aviation sector is evident, as it dominates most of tourist inflow into India. This highlights the importance of maintaining, strengthening and encouraging the country's aviation industry to facilitate the growth and success of the tourism sector.

Figure 12: Modes of transport for Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs) in 2019



Note: Data pertains to 2019. However, it's important to note that data for 2020 and 2021 may not accurately reflect the situation due to the significant impact of the Covid-19 pandemic. The pandemic has caused unprecedented disruptions in the travel industry, making any conclusions drawn from the data during these years potentially misleading.
Source: Ministry of Tourism

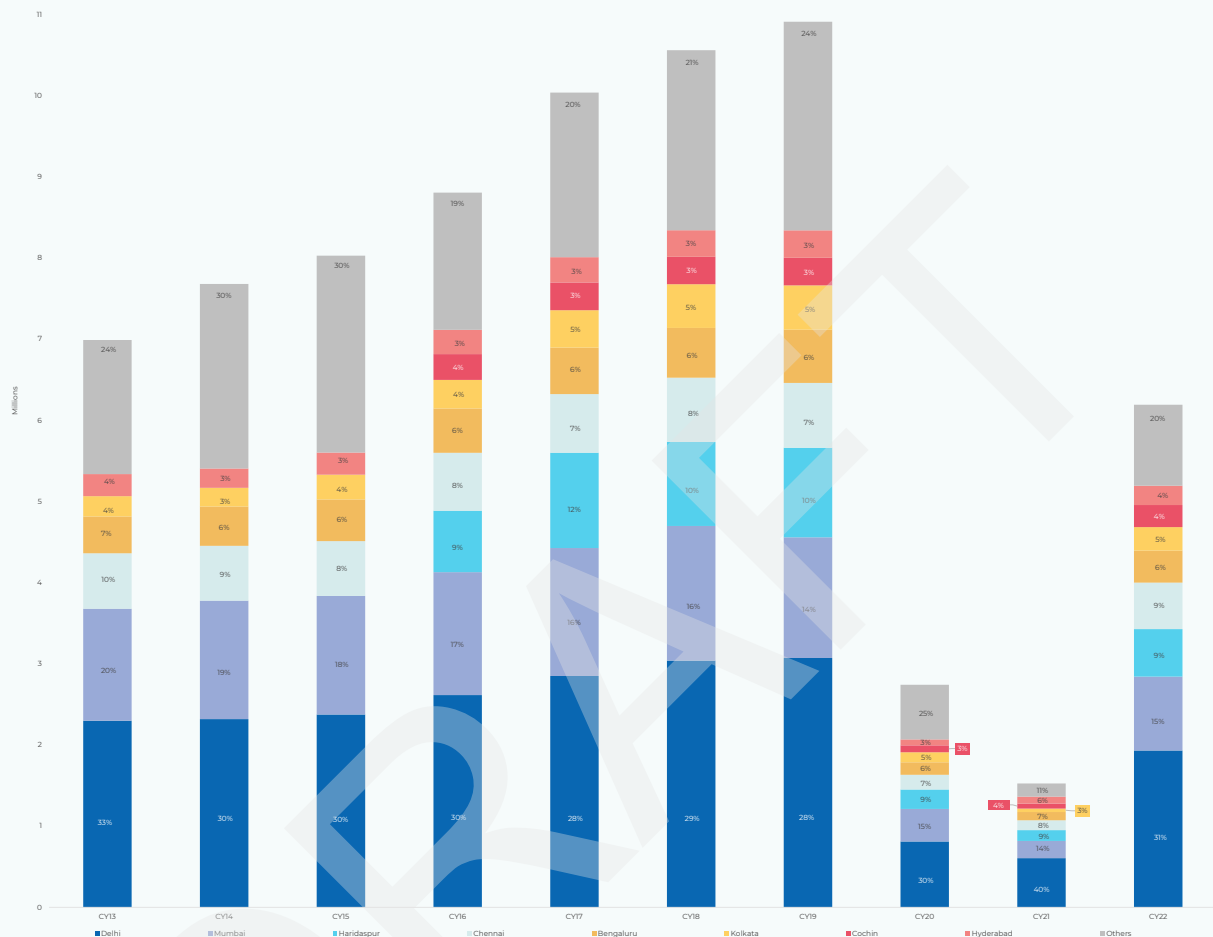
Delhi and Mumbai, being homes to the two largest airports in India, play a significant role in attracting tourists into the country. These airports serve as major gateways, allowing travellers to easily access other parts of India. Additionally, foreign airlines prefer operating to these destinations, due to the substantial passenger numbers and well-developed infrastructure and coupled healthy connectivity options to other airports through these.

Together, Delhi and Mumbai account for more than half of the tourist inflow into India. However, it is worth noting that the land border at Haridaspur, which connects Bangladesh, ranks third among the ports of entry to India. This is mainly because Bangladesh accounts for nearly 25% of the total tourist inflow into India, thus contributing significantly to the overall tourism numbers.





Figure 13: Top ports of entry for Foreign Tourist Arrivals (FTAs)



Source: Ministry of Tourism



Growth drivers



Rising income

- Growth in disposable income, driven by rising income, serves as a potent catalyst for the expansion of tourism, as it provides the financial capacity to explore and engage in tourism activities, both domestic and International.
- The **per-capita income** for the **world** has risen from **\$10,920²** in calendar year 2013 to \$13,330² in calendar year 2023.
- For the top 10 global tourism source countries by outbound tourist, per-capita income increased by 63% to \$37,099² over the decade until 2023
- For the top 10 source countries for India by inbound tourist as of 2019, per-capita income increased 65% during the same period to \$35,093².



Amenities

- Enhanced amenities, spanning accommodation transportation and recreational facilities, have played a pivotal role in shaping the tourism landscape. Quality amenities not only attract tourists, but also encourage extended stays, increased exploration and positive recommendations, fostering sustained tourism growth. Furthermore, the number of hotel rooms in India rose to 1,00,929 as of April 30, 2023 from 75,353⁸ in 2013. The number of tour operators have also surged to 795 from 188⁸ over the period, further contributing to the tourism infrastructure



Diverse and vibrant destinations

- India has a lot to offer to tourists – from historical monuments such as Taj Mahal and Red Fort, to wildlife safaris. The country's scenic landscapes, beaches and vibrant culture make it an attractive destination that caters to a wide range of interests for global travellers



Digitalisation

- Improvement in internet connectivity and the widespread use of social media platforms have greatly driven domestic tourism in India. With easy access to travel information, online booking facilities and engaging content on social media, more Indians are inspired to explore the country's diverse destinations, leading to a surge in domestic travel and tourism activities.
- The count of internet subscribers surged from 198.39⁷ million in 2013 to 895.83 million by the end of June 2023, signifying a rise in internet adoption from 15.4% of the Indian population in 2013 to 63.2% in 2023

2 International Monetary Fund
7 Telecom Regulatory Authority of India
8 Ministry of Tourism



Enhanced connectivity

- Improved flight connections and road/rail networks help open a wider number of destinations as well as encourage travel
- **Air:** The domestic aircraft fleet increased to 726³ in June 2023 from 395 in fiscal 2014, whereas the number of airports doubled to 148 in 2023 from 74 in 2014. As India is a supply driven market, wherein increased fleet capacity drives passenger numbers, rising number of aircraft and airports will increase passenger numbers
- **Road:** Better road connectivity and length of national highways increasing to 1,44,955⁵ km in fiscal 2023 from 1,00,475 km in fiscal 2016 have supported an increase in tourist flows. Also, improving road infrastructure and rising sales of sport utility vehicles (accounting for 52% of passenger vehicle sales in the first half of fiscal 2024 vs. 14% in fiscal 2014) have aided long-distance road trips



Rising trend of niche tourism

- Niche tourism is characterised by specialised interests and unique experiences. Whether it is cultural, adventure, wildlife, wellness or heritage tourism, India offers a wide range of niche experiences. This trend is not only attracting a new segment of travellers seeking tailored and immersive experiences, but is also driving economic opportunities for local communities. The promotion and development of niche tourism contribute to a more diversified and resilient tourism sector, ultimately enhancing the overall appeal of India as a multifaceted travel destination. In fact, medical tourism has seen traction in recent years, with visitors seeking medical services rising to 6,97,357⁸ in 2019 from 4,27,014 in 2016



³ Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA)
⁵ Ministry of Road Transport and Highways
⁸ Ministry of Tourism

Government schemes and policies

Swadesh Darshan

Union Budget 2023-24 allocated Rs 1,412 crore to revamp the Swadesh Darshan 2.0 scheme for 76 sanctioned projects and 15 tourist circuits in 31 states and union territories (UTs). The scheme was launched in fiscal 2015 to:

**SWADESH
DARSHAN**

- Develop tourism infrastructure
- Promote culture and heritage in identified regions to generate livelihood
- Position tourism as the main engine of economic growth and job creation
- Adopt a community development and pro-poor tourism approach
- Develop tourism services to improve visitor experience/interest



PRASHAD

Union Budget 2023-24 allocated Rs 250 crore to the National Mission on Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual Augmentation Drive (PRASHAD) scheme for development of 45 projects sanctioned in 30 states/UTs.

The scheme was launched in fiscal 2015 to:

- Develop 50 tourist destinations
- Develop identified pilgrimage destinations
- Develop infrastructure, connectivity and border linkages
- Undertake Vibrant Village Programme
- Promote one district, one product
- Give central financial assistance to the state governments for promoting tourism





Travel for LiFE Programme

Travel for LiFE Programme, part of Mission LiFE, advocates sustainable tourism in India by encouraging tourists and businesses to take simple actions that benefit the environment, local economies and communities. Aligned with Sustainable Development Goals, it focuses on specific, measurable and easy-to-implement actions under the pillars of environmental sustainability, biodiversity protection, economic sustainability and sustainable tourism certification.



24x7 multilingual tourist info-helpline

Tourism authorities provide a 24X7 helpline, offering assistance to tourists in multiple languages. This ensures travellers have access to essential information and support throughout their journey.



Marketing Development Assistance

The scheme provides financial aid to state tourism departments and various entities, such as travel agents, hotels, and online aggregators. Eligible activities include overseas marketing initiatives, travel fair participation, and road shows and online promotions of tourism destinations.



Champion Services Sector Scheme

As part of a pilot initiative, the Incentive to Tour Operators for Enhancing Tourist Arrivals to India scheme will extend financial incentives to selected foreign tour operators and approved inbound tour operators from designated countries.



Scheme of Capacity Building for Service Providers (CBSP)

The scheme aims to address the rising demand for skilled human resources in the tourism sector. CBSP bridges the gap by offering training and certification for both organised and unorganised segments, covering basic skill development for newcomers and enhancing the expertise of existing service providers.

Promoting India as a tourist hotspot: Way forward

A. Improving India's branding and positioning

- Better branding and tourism promotion strategy can improve India's position in the tourism attractiveness index and attract higher number of inbound tourists. The country can be positioned as an all-season tourism destination owing to its varied climatic conditions, i.e. beaches in the South in the winter season and the Himalayan region during the summer. In fact, the country's natural beauty and its offer of a wide range of tourist experiences for all age groups and demographics ensure a wider audience
- Social media is a pivotal component for individuals seeking to explore and discover travel destinations. Considering the vast user base, with Facebook boasting 2.99⁹ billion monthly active users and Instagram hosting 28 billion monthly active users as of March 31, 2023, India could benefit from formulating a social media policy. This approach can effectively spotlight the country's diverse tourism experiences, spanning culture, nature and niche tourism. As travellers leverage these platforms to instantly share their experiences, it amplifies the promotion of tourism in India, potentially drawing a larger influx of visitors to the country
- The Ministry of Tourism has already recognised culture, nature and niche tourism as key areas for development; India's abundant and distinctive cultural and natural attractions can be leveraged to provide diverse experiences for different types of tourists. In fact, the country is an ideal destination for niche tourism because of its abundance of wildlife sanctuaries and diverse landscapes, providing excellent opportunities for adventure. To promote niche tourism, successful practices employed by other nations can be studied and implemented in India as well, and collaborations can be undertaken with the Ministry of External Affairs to effectively promote India as a tourist destination

From Eco-Havens to Creative Campaigns: Global Tourism Embraces Sustainability and Innovation

Key tourist destinations across India have implemented ecofriendly practices to minimise pollution and contamination of natural resources. All national parks and wildlife sanctuaries have minimised the use of plastic and replaced these with biodegradable materials. Also, Thenmala, India's first ecotourist destination, promotes sustainable tourism by offering ecofriendly activities, such as hiking, snorkelling and bird watching. Other tourist destinations in India can implement similar initiatives to promote ecofriendly and sustainable tourism. Also, several countries have implemented innovative experiential marketing campaigns to promote tourism. Travel Wisconsin utilised a funhouse mirror at bus stops, showcasing local activities like tubing to spark interest. Canada enticed Europeans with pop-up restaurants featuring Canadian cuisine, along with a media push. Australia's "There's Nothing Like Australia" campaign incorporates pop-up events and virtual reality experiences to showcase diverse landscapes and iconic landmarks. Japan's "Cool Japan" campaign immerses fans in pop culture through anime conventions and themed cafes. Italy's "Italia: Live from Italy" employs live streaming for virtual experiences, offering glimpses of the country's culture, art, and cuisine to a global audience



B. Improved connectivity

- To enhance tourist arrivals to India, several measures can be taken, including the construction and operationalisation of new international airports. The initiatives can contribute to improving the country's tourism infrastructure, connectivity and accessibility, thus attracting more tourists to India. Also, while the country has entered into air service agreements with 116 countries to enhance air connectivity, not all are fully operationalised
- Indian airlines have 1,000+¹⁰ aircraft on order, which will boost passenger capacity. India, being a supply-driven market, should benefit from the induction of aircraft, thereby supporting tourism numbers
- Another step towards enhancing tourism connectivity has been the increase in the highway construction target for fiscal 2024 to 13,800 km, up from the previous goal of 12,500 km. Extension in the length of national highways improves accessibility to regions for tourists
- Also, the Indian Railways' announcement to introduce 3,000¹¹ new trains will boost domestic tourism. Newer trains such as Vande Bharat and Vistadome coaches, and additional heritage railways could be explored to boost tourism via railways
- Helipads and jetties play a crucial role in providing last mile connectivity, especially in hilly areas. A shrine in Jammu has helicopter services for devotees and tourists with mobility issues. This improved accessibility is estimated to have increased devotees visiting the shrine. Similar helicopter and cable car services can be made available at other mountainous regions to improve connectivity and accessibility
- Wayside amenities such as parking spaces, restrooms, eateries, essential item stores along key tourist roads will provide employment as well as improve the tourist experience
- Last-mile connectivity stands as a crucial strategy for propelling tourism in India, closing the gap between transportation hubs and tourist destinations, especially in remote areas. By bolstering efficient road networks and local transportation services, last-mile connectivity not only enhances the overall travel experience but also promotes the exploration of offbeat locations. Aligned with the Swadesh Darshan Scheme, components like last-mile connectivity play a pivotal role in enhancing accessibility and infrastructure, fostering the sustainable growth of India's tourism sector

Policy and regulatory reforms

To By simplifying and streamlining the visa process, including expanding visa-on-arrival facilities or waiving visa requirements to more countries, India can make the process more straightforward and convenient for potential visitors

India's Visa Bonanza Sparks Tourism Surge

On June 28, 2021, the Indian government initiated a scheme offering the first five lakh tourist visas no charges for e-tourist as well as regular tourist visas. This step led to the issuance of 1,27,999 regular tourist visas and 2,27,225 e-tourist visas¹². The scheme was valid until March 31, 2022, or until the issuance of the first 5 lakh tourist visas, whichever came first

Several Asian countries, namely Indonesia, Malaysia, Sri Lanka, Thailand and Vietnam, have waived-off/have announced plans to waive-off visa requirements for Indian and nationals from other countries with an aim to boost tourist numbers

¹⁰ Boeing and Airbus

¹¹ Ministry of Railways

¹² Lok Sabha Question – Ministry of Tourism

Offering suitable financial incentives

India can consider providing tax breaks and other similar incentives, as this is a strategy already being adopted by several countries. This could positively impact the economy by stimulating increased spending by foreign tourists and encouraging their overall engagement with the local economy. Commonly known as tax-free shopping or falling under tax refund schemes, this practice is widely implemented in popular tourist destinations globally. France, Mexico, Spain, Singapore and China already offer tax refunds to tourists, allowing them to recover a portion of the taxes paid on eligible purchases

Improving private sector participation

The government can encourage collaborations with the private sector to boost tourism and improve infrastructure. This involves offering incentives to private stakeholders for investing in tourism infrastructure and facilitating public-private partnerships to develop tourism. By fostering such partnerships, the government can stimulate growth in tourism and enhance the overall infrastructure for visitors

Private Ventures Transform India's Tourism Landscape

Private sector involvement in tourism is exemplified by projects such as the eco-tourism resort development in Lalaji Bay, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and the eco-tourism resort initiative on Minicoy Island, Lakshadweep. Additionally, the operation and maintenance of the North-East Tribal Museum and Cultural Centre in Nazirakhat, Assam, showcase successful instances of private sector participation in promoting tourism

Creating a tourist and women-friendly environment

Establishing an environment that caters to the needs of tourists, particularly women, is crucial. Ensuring the safety of foreign visitors is paramount for encouraging prolonged stays and increased spending in foreign currency. Women safety requires special attention. This can be achieved by implementing women-friendly tourist packages, including services such as women tourist guides, women-operated taxi services, and dedicated women-only sections in reputable hotels and accommodations.

Breaking Barriers: Kerala's Bold Step Towards Inclusivity with Women-Friendly Tourism

The **Department of Tourism, Kerala** has initiated a **women-friendly tourism** project, aiming to promote the active involvement of women in all tourism activities and attract a greater number of female tourists to the state. This proactive initiative seeks to bring about a significant shift, especially in a time when there is a noticeable surge in solo trips by women worldwide

Improving hygiene standards

Ensuring a pleasant experience for tourists necessitates upholding the highest hygiene standards across various aspects of their interactions. This includes maintaining cleanliness of facilities such as restrooms, public spaces such as train and bus stations, streets, and all types of dining establishments. Recognising the pivotal role that food plays in the tourist experience, the creation of dedicated food streets offering a blend of local and global cuisines becomes essential. These food streets should adhere to the best hygiene practices, thereby contributing to an elevated and enhanced travel experience.

LiFE campaign for clean destinations

The Ministry of Tourism recently launched the Travel for LiFE for Cleanliness Campaign, aligning with the ongoing Swachhata Hi Sewa fortnight. This initiative underscores India's commitment to cleanliness and environmental sustainability. To bolster the Swachh Bharat mission, the Ministry established a Project Monitoring Unit on December 9, 2015. This unit focuses on enhancing hygiene, sanitation, and overall cleanliness at tourist destinations, aiming to attract both domestic and foreign tourists. The SBM Division plays a crucial role in coordinating Swachhta Awareness activities among tourists, students, and various stakeholders in the tourism sector.

Tourism circuit development

The central government launched Swadesh Darshan Scheme in 2015 to provide assistance to state governments to develop thematic tourist circuits based on specific themes, such as spirituality, pilgrimage, culture and heritage, or eco-friendly tourism. Rajasthan Tourism Department has curated a tourist circuit for the Golden Triangle, which is a tourist package designed for travellers who want to explore Delhi, Agra and Jaipur with accommodation at a 3-star hotel.

Beyond Boundaries: India's Tourism Thrust on Adventure, Eco, and Sustainable Travel

The Ministry of Tourism is strategically promoting Adventure Tourism, Eco Tourism, and Sustainable Tourism, recognizing them as niche products to showcase India, including Assam and other North Eastern States, as year-round destinations. The aim is to attract tourists with specific interests and ensure repeat visits, distinguishing India from competing destinations. Additionally, there is a dedicated focus on the development of religious and pilgrim tourism. Through flagship schemes like Swadesh Darshan and PRASHAD, the Ministry emphasizes the enhancement of tourism infrastructure and facilities. The Swadesh Darshan Scheme outlines 15 themes for developing theme-based circuits, encompassing diverse attractions such as Buddhist, Coastal, Heritage, Himalayan, and Wildlife Circuits.

Thematic tourism

Swadesh Darshan 2.0, which was launched in 2023, is an evolution of Swadesh Darshan Scheme to develop sustainable and responsible tourism destinations. The following major themes have been identified for tourism under the scheme: Culture and heritage, adventure tourism, eco-tourism, wellness tourism, MICE tourism, rural tourism, beach tourism, and cruises – ocean and inland.

LiFE campaign for clean destinations

State governments have been taking active initiatives to promote each of the themes in their respective states. The Government of Meghalaya set up Meghalaya Basin Development Authority in 2011 that aims to address the management of natural resources in the state while addressing issues of livelihood among the rural communities, along with encouraging tourism in the state.

Promoting cultural and heritage tourism

The central government launched PRASHAD scheme to improve infrastructure at pilgrimage sites and connectivity. This scheme focuses on developing and identifying pilgrimage sites across India for enriching the religious tourism experience. It aims to integrate pilgrimage destinations in a prioritised, planned and sustainable manner to provide a complete religious tourism experience. To be sure, the growth of domestic tourism hugely depends on pilgrimage tourism.



